Your Window of Tolerance

Your Window of Tolerance (a concept from Dr. Dan Siegel) is the zone where you can handle life's ups and downs. When stress pushes you out of it, your body shifts into survival mode. That's not a failure. It's your nervous system trying to protect you.

HYPERAROUSAL (Fight / Flight)

Thoughts: racing, 'I can't handle this,' worst-case
Feelings: anxious, angry, panicky, overwhelmed
Body: racing heart, tight muscles, fast breath, restless

What helps (calm down):

slow exhale breathing, cold water, grounding 5-4-3-2-1, gentle movement.

WINDOW OF TOLERANCE (ANCHORED)



Thoughts: clear, curious, 'I can handle this'
Feelings: calm, safe, connected, present
Body: steady breath, relaxed muscles, grounded

HYPOAROUSAL (Freeze / Shutdown)

Thoughts: foggy, blank, 'what's the point'
Feelings: numb, empty, hopeless, checked out
Body: heavy, tired, slow, low energy, frozen

What helps (wake up):

movement, strong taste or scent, cold splash, stand up and stretch, music.

Where am I right now?

☐ Hyperaroused ☐ In my window ☐ Hypoaroused

My signs: _____

_____

What widens my window: _____

_____

Anchored Inside Counseling Services. This is not a substitute for therapy. In crisis call or text 988.